re-entry into the government – first with his position on the Eastern Committee and then as acting foreign secretary – he found himself in 1918–1919 finally able to shape Britain's foreign policy. As his biographer Nicolson put it, the post-war period presented Curzon with the opportunity to enact his 'complete, final, perfected plan': to consolidate, once and for all, Britain's presence in southern Asia and secure India from any future foreign threat.[32] In the words of Curzon himself, in December 1918, now was the opportune time for the Persians to 'realise that the iron hand lay beneath the velvet glove'. Curzon's policy towards Persia in 1918 and 1919 would exemplify his Great Game mentality, although he would find opposition to his endeavours at every turn in the form of the Indian government, which much preferred 'to give the "velvet glove" a chance'.[33]

Joining Curzon in his Persian quest in the post-war period was Sir Percy Cox, newly appointed chargé d'affaires in Tehran (the previous British minister, Sir Charles Marling proving too inefficient for London's liking).[34] Cox certainly appeared more pro-active than Marling, and immediately upon his appointment, in November 1918, began to inundate the Foreign Office with his ideas for the direction of British policy in Persia. In the opinion of the new chargé d'affaires, the collapse of Russia's presence in Asia presented the perfect opportunity for Britain to extend and solidify its position in Persia. Noting that the 'suspension of Russia's existence gives us a free field for our labours', Cox was soon suggesting that Britain should try to gain a mandate for Persia from America.[35] Such a move would give freer rein in Persia, as it would provide international legitimacy to Britain's position of influence in that country. The focus on Russia as the prime target of Britain's policy in Persia matched Curzon's own beliefs. (That Cox and Curzon thought so alike is unsurprising given that the two had a history: Cox had been appointed by Curzon in 1899 as Consul in Muscat and had travelled up the Persian Gulf with Curzon when he was viceroy).[36] The government of India, however, was alarmed at Cox's suggestion, Chelmsford arguing that the cost and military commitment that such a move would necessitate would be a drain on Indian resources that could not be justified so far as India's interests were concerned.[37] Cox countered that the viceroy did not appreciate how much the situation in Persia had changed with the 'alarming spread of Bolshevism and revolutionary ideas... As it is, the Shah is extremely apprehensive of [the] spread of Bolshevism.'[38]